

IN3065/INM355 User-Centred System Design 2025–2026

Coursework Brief: StudyBuddy

Introduction

This module is assessed through two interconnected coursework parts that together form a single design project. To deliver this project you will *individually* follow a User-Centred Design (UCD) approach to meet a given design brief. Overall, the assignment is worth 100% of the module marks, with the two parts weighted as follows:

Coursework	Focus	Weight	Deadline(s)
Part 1 (CW1)	User research plan & supporting materials	10%	Submission: Sun 08 March 2026, 17:00 Presentations: 09–12 March (schedule TBA)
Part 2 (CW2)	User research, Design & Evaluation	90%	Sun 03 May 2026, 17:00

Please note that Coursework Part 1 is exempt from the University's [Extensions and Late Submissions Policy](#)

1. The Design Challenge

The University is planning to develop StudyBuddy, a digital app with potential service elements, to help students plan and manage their studying, including *study sessions*, i.e. bounded blocks of studying/work. The team responsible for StudyBuddy want it to meet real user needs and provide optimal usability and UX.

For this coursework, your task is to design some of StudyBuddy's features, informed by user research that you will also undertake. Your solution may support individual study, group study, or both, but it must be designed to support at least one complete end-to-end user journey related to planning or managing studying. The relationship to your user research must be evident and traceable.

Learning outcomes

By completing this coursework, you will demonstrate your ability to:

- Plan and conduct user research with real participants.
- Synthesise findings into actionable needs and requirements.
- Create and justify UCD artefacts (e.g. current user journey map, persona).
- Design a coherent interaction flow and wireframes, specifying interaction design in detail.
- Propose an appropriate evaluation plan.

Design scope and constraints

In scope

Your design might address, based on evidence from your user research:

- Deciding what to study (task selection, breakdown, “definition of done”...)
- Finding or choosing a suitable study space (quiet/collab, equipment needs, crowding, travel, comfort...)
- Coordinating a group session (agreeing goals, time/place, roles, follow-up...)
- Starting a session and maintaining momentum (setup, interruptions, transitions...)
- Wrapping up a session (capturing outcomes, next steps, continuity...)

Out of scope

- A generic calendar/to-do app with no study-session or space-specific insight
- An “everything about student life” platform—stay focused on study session user journeys.

2. Your Task

You must follow a **user-centred design process**, completing all stages and delivering all required outputs.

Stage 1: User Research

Plan and conduct user research, to inform the design of StudyBuddy. Identify your potential audience(s), and design semi-structured interviews to elicit rich, detailed information relevant to the brief—as a rough guide, aim for at least 20 minutes per interview. You will need to find out what existing processes, behaviours and interactions StudyBuddy would ideally support or augment. Design your interviews to tease out *detail* that will be useful for designing StudyBuddy, and identify opportunities to improve or enhance the current situation.

At least two of your interviews must incorporate some kind of observation or walkthrough of something related to the brief, e.g. participant reconstructs a recent study session (what task, where, why, what tools, any interruptions, what “done” looked like, etc), or demonstrates how they chose/choose a study space (including any trade-offs, constraints etc), or shows how they coordinate group work (if relevant).

To design and conduct these interviews, draw upon learnings from lectures and assigned readings, following guidance and best practice.

Your User Research plan and draft research materials will be assessed through CW1 (coursework part 1).

Interview participants & recruitment

A minimum of **4 individual interviews** must be conducted with potential users of StudyBuddy.

- Interviewees must be adults (aged 18+).
- Interviewing students currently enrolled in IN3065/INM355 is not allowed.

Important: Ethics requirements

You must follow an ethical approach for your user research. Informed consent must be obtained from all participants, with the real name and contact details (email or phone number) of the participant captured on their consent form—for City St George’s students, please collect their University email address. You must also use a participant information sheet. Adapt the ethics templates that are provided on the module Moodle page. Signed consent forms must eventually be collated into one PDF file, submitted to the designated area as part of CW2. Any suspected fabrication or falsification of participants, informed consent, or failure to meet the above ethics requirements, will be investigated as academic misconduct.

Conducting and recording interviews

Interviews can be conducted in-person or remotely, but must be *verbal* and *synchronous*. Note that sharing questions with participants in advance and allowing them to prepare answers is not an acceptable way to conduct these interviews. Nor is any form of text-mediated interview, e.g. via WhatsApp chat, Slack or email.

Interviews must be video recorded (if doing remote interviews, consider using MS Teams), with participants’ faces shown in the recordings, and the raw data (videos) submitted as proof that the sessions took place. You may wish to have some kind of secondary recording method, as backup, in case of technology failure.

Data analysis and outputs

Analyse the research data you collected, using *appropriate methods*, to produce detailed findings, relevant to the brief. Create a **current user journey map**, representing a current user journey discovered through your research, either for a particular participant or aggregate of multiple participants.

Use your findings to decide on one or more clear **design goals**, identifying the target user(s), context and study session problem you plan to address through design, and list (briefly) any key requirements. Create a **persona** for the primary user type whose needs you will design to address, considering their goals, behaviours, constraints. The relationship between the research data gathered and any deliverables should be evident/traceable.

Stage 1 (User Research) Deliverables

Your User Research plan and draft research materials will be assessed through **CW1 (coursework part 1)**.

Your **CW2 (coursework part 2)** submission must include the following:

Main report body

- **User Research Methodology:** Summarise how you conducted the user research, including the analysis (max 250 words).
- **User Research Results:** Describe the results from your user research (max 600 words). Begin this section with a very brief outline of who took part (interview participants), then summarise your findings in appropriate detail (key themes and insights), with reference to the data. Follow with clearly stated design goal(s) for the next stage of the project, and any key requirements, derived from user research.
- **1 x Current User Journey Map**, grounded in evidence, showing how students currently manage or complete a study session (include pain points and decision points) (1 x A4/A3 page).
- **1 x Primary Persona** (1 x A4 page) grounded in evidence. This should be accompanied by a written description (max 200 words) of how the persona was created, with specific reference to your data.

Report appendices

- Informed consent form template (Final version), Participant information sheet (Final version), Interview guide/script (final version); Full list of findings from the interviews; Observation notes / screenshots; Any evidence of analyses, including summaries of individual interviews, images of affinity diagramming, etc; Any other materials / outputs produced as part of the user research.

Data (OneDrive)

- Interview video recordings (video files uploaded to a OneDrive Folder)
- Interview transcripts (any full/verbatim transcripts of the interviews)

Stage 2: Design

Use the learnings and outputs from your user research to design interaction (screens and behaviour) to support at least one key user journey within the StudyBuddy app in full. Prioritise features specific to StudyBuddy, rather than standard ones like login and registration procedures.

Start this section of your report with a written introduction explaining and justifying your **choice of wireframes**. Briefly describe the user journey(s) you have chosen to address through design.

To provide a visual overview of the user's journey within the StudyBuddy app, produce a **flow diagram** that illustrates the transitions between the screens designed. This must focus on the wireframed user journey(s).

Produce a set of **annotated wireframes (x6)**, documenting the appearance and interaction design of screens encountered during the user journey(s). This work should be clearly grounded in your preceding work, and informed by HCI design principles and guidelines.

Choose your wireframes and user journey(s) wisely. Ensure there is enough complexity to demonstrate your design skills to their greatest extent. If the chosen user journey involves fewer than 6 screens, choose additional screens to wireframe as well, to bring the number of wireframes up to 6.

Wireframes should be *neat* and *detailed*—aim for a professional look and feel. They must be produced using software such as Balsamiq, Figma, Axure, PowerPoint, or any other application you choose, but you must not use GenAI to produce them—this must be your own work. Submit mid-fidelity wireframes as a minimum; you can submit designs of a higher fidelity but this will not gain you extra marks.

Annotate your wireframes thoroughly, detailing the interaction design. The annotated wireframes should serve as a specification of the interactive features and behaviours of these screens—failure to deliver an appropriate level of detail, thoroughness and completeness will result in lower marks. Each wireframe must be on its own page, with annotations located on the same page.

Stage 2 (Design) Deliverables

Your **CW2 (coursework part 2)** submission must include the following:

Main report body

- **Choice of Wireframes:** Written introduction explaining your choice of user journey(s) and wireframes.
- **Flow diagram,** showing the flow of the user journey(s), including transitions between screens designed.
- **Annotated wireframes** (x6), for at least one key user journey (6 screens in total, 1 x A4/A3 page *for each screen design*)

You are not required to implement your proposed solution as a working system or clickable prototype.

Stage 3: Evaluation (Usability testing plan)

You must now decide how to evaluate your design of StudyBuddy, to understand how well it meets the needs of its intended audience, based on your user research, and what might be improved.

Imagine you have access to a usability testing facility, such as City Interaction Lab. Prepare a **usability testing plan** for them to evaluate StudyBuddy for you, focusing on the *usability* and *user experience* of the system.

Your plan should address the *evaluation aim*, *participants* (who and how many), and the testing *environment setup*, including *equipment*, and any *materials* to be used. Describe what *data* should be captured and how.

Create *3 task scenarios*, tied to the relevant user journey(s), and provide the exact task wording. For each task, say what you hope to learn from it, and provide some observable success criteria.

Outline the *procedure* for the usability test session, showing the order and timing of activities.

Stage 3 (Evaluation) Deliverables

Your CW2 (coursework part 2) submission must include the following:

Main report body

- **Usability testing plan:** incorporating all requirements in the Stage 3 description. (max 450 words)

3. Submission

CW1 (coursework part 1)

Working *individually*, you must:

1. Plan user research, using appropriate techniques.
2. Create relevant documents to support/conduct your research ('Research materials').
3. Prepare a presentation (max 5 minutes) that explains your user research plan.
4. Submit the presentation slides and your research materials to Moodle as 'Supporting Materials'.
5. Deliver the presentation in person, followed by a brief Q&A.

Presentation of research plan (in person)

Deadline: A designated presentation slot during the week of 9–13 March 2026.

You must deliver a **verbal presentation** (max. 5 mins) that explains your research plan.

The presentation must be delivered in person, at the scheduled time. Only the marker(s) will be in attendance. Presentations will be recorded, as necessary for moderation purposes, but data privacy will be assured.

You will have up to 5 minutes for your presentation, and it will be followed by a brief Q&A. Timing will be strict, so ensure that you practise delivering your presentation, and arrive on time for your designated presentation slot.

The presentation should incorporate the following:

1. **Research aim / focus** (including if you only plan to focus on a specific aspect of StudyBuddy).
2. **Interview participants**: who you plan to involve, and how you will recruit them.
3. **Ethics**: How you will ensure ethical involvement of participants (and their data).
4. **Interview setup and logistics**: Where, when, how long etc, equipment needed.
5. **Data**: What you will collect, and how you will collect it.
6. **Interview guide**: The goals of the interview, the structure of the interview guide/script, and the main topics / key lines of questioning.
7. **Walkthroughs/observations**: What you hope to focus on and how this will work in practice.
8. **Data analysis**: How you will analyse the data collected.
9. Any other relevant information.

Supporting materials (submit via Moodle)

Submission deadline: 8th March 2026, 17:00 (5pm).

You must submit a **single PDF** containing the following, to the [designated CW1 submission point on Moodle](#). Written text in this PDF must be searchable.

- **Cover page** containing your name, module code and year, and a table of contents (A4)
- **Presentation slide deck** (A4, max 2 slides per page)
- **Research materials** (A4)—Any materials required to conduct your planned research, including:
 - Participant information sheet (for the interviews)
 - Informed consent form template (for the interviews)
 - Interview guide/script
 - Any other relevant materials, e.g. if you are planning to use a screener, questionnaire or observation template, include it.
- **Log of any [Gen]AI use**—including prompts/inputs, outputs and uses. (A4)

CW2 (coursework part 2)

Working *individually*, you must:

1. Conduct **user research**, using appropriate techniques.
2. **Analyse** collected data to identify **findings** relevant to the brief.
3. Create a **current user journey map** of a study session user journey identified through your research.
4. Formulate clear **design goal(s) and requirements** to guide your subsequent design work, as well as a **primary persona** to represent the key user type—all must be grounded in your user research.
5. Create a **user flow diagram**, to provide a visual overview of the path through StudyBuddy that a user will take to complete a user journey for which you design screens/interaction.
6. Produce **annotated wireframes** (x6) to document the interaction design of key screens in your chosen user journey. Ensure that annotations are of a specification level.
7. Create a **usability testing plan** for testing your designs.
8. Create and submit a **report** (PDF) containing the required deliverables and any **supporting materials**. Upload all **raw data** (interview recordings) to a OneDrive folder.

Submission deadline: Sunday 3rd May 2026, 17:00 (5pm).

You should submit 2 x **PDF** files to Moodle, to the [designated CW2 submission point](#):

1. The main report (including appendices)
2. A file collating all of your signed informed consent forms.

You must also save your raw data—interview video recordings—to a OneDrive folder. Share the folder with the module leader, and provide the folder URL in the report. This must be uploaded by the deadline too.

Main report (PDF 1, submit via Moodle)

Your main report must contain, in this structure/order:

Cover page	– Include your Name, Module code and Year, OneDrive data folder location (URL) and a Table of Contents (A4)
Section 1: User Research	– 1.1. User Research Methodology (250 words max, A4). – 1.2. User Research Results (600 words max, A4). – 1.3. Current User Journey Map (1 x A4 or A3 page). – 1.4. Primary Persona (1 x A4 page). – 1.4.1. Person Creation Method (200 words max).
Section 2: Design	– 2.1. Wireframes Intro – 2.1 Flow Diagram (1 x A4 or A3 page) – 2.2. Annotated Wireframes (x6) (Each wireframe must be on its own A4 or A3 page, along with annotations).
Section 3: Evaluation	– 3. Usability Testing Plan (450 words max, A4).
References	– (A4)
Appendices	– Relevant additional materials and outputs produced during the process, e.g. Informed consent form template (final), Participant information sheet (final), Interview guide/script (final); Complete findings; Interview summaries and other evidence of analyses; Sketches; Any other relevant materials/outputs produced, etc (A4 or A3, as appropriate for each).
GenAI log (if relevant)	– Log of any [Gen]AI use—including prompts/inputs, outputs and uses (A4)

- Text in this PDF must be searchable/selectable. As well as any written sections, this includes text in the persona content, user journey content and wireframe annotations.
- No personally identifiable information must be included in this report. User participant IDs (e.g. P1, P2 etc) instead of participant names.

Signed Informed Consent Forms (PDF 2, submit via Moodle)

This single PDF file must contain all of your signed informed consent forms from study participants, with contact details (real name plus email or phone number will suffice).

Raw Data (Interview video recordings, share OneDrive folder)

You must also save your raw data—e.g. interview video recordings—to a University OneDrive folder by the deadline. Share the folder with the Module Leader (give them *Edit* permissions), and provide the folder URL in the submitted PDF. Any full/verbatim transcripts of recordings can be stored in the same folder.

Once the submission deadline has passed, do not open any of the items in the OneDrive folder—only files timestamped before the deadline will be considered to have been submitted on time.

4. Further requirements

Coursework delivery

General:

- You must include all elements indicated in the coursework specification.
- Make sure that your submissions look good and read well.
- Stay within specified maximum word limits. Anything beyond the stated maximum will be ignored.
- Content quality should not degrade on magnification. Content with poor resolution will affect the associated section marks for presentation.

User Flow Diagram (10%)

- Quality and efficacy of flow diagram, including clarity, logic, detail, accuracy and presentation.
- Relationship to the wireframes.

Wireframes (40%)

- Choice of wireframes/features designed; Relationship to user research findings.
- Quality of interaction design, including coherence of design elements and interaction logic and application of design principles and guidelines.
- Quality of annotations—clarity, detail, completeness.
- Presentation quality.

Usability Testing Plan (5%)

- Detail and appropriateness of suggested approach; Demonstration of good practice in plan.
- Quality of usability testing tasks.

Report (5%):

- Quality of writing, including clarity, coherence, conciseness and correctness.
- Effectiveness of content organisation, structure and headings.
- Quality of presentation, including neatness and styling/formatting choices.
- Effectiveness of navigation (e.g. page numbering, table of contents, PDF bookmarks).
- Quality of referencing (e.g. accuracy, completeness, adherence to Harvard style)
- Overall format, including adherence to requirements (e.g. page size, text searchability, etc).

Grade bands IN3065

%	Grade description	Knowledge demonstrated in the submission	Presentation & communication
80-100	Outstanding (High Distinction)	An outstanding submission. Demonstrates comprehensive knowledge. Addresses all assessment criteria in the marking scheme in full and is of a professional standard. Exceptionally strong evidence of creativity, independent and critical thinking, and reading of related work that is outside of the required reading.	Exceptionally well structured, exceptionally well crafted, and exceptionally well delivered. Exceptionally clear and coherent.
70-79	Excellent (Distinction)	An excellent submission. Demonstrates very strong knowledge. Very strong critical analysis evident. Addresses all assessment criteria in the marking scheme very well. Evidence of comprehensive reading of required material, and some reading of related work beyond this.	Very well structured, very well crafted and very well delivered. Very clear and coherent
60-69	Good (Merit)	A good submission. Demonstrates good knowledge. Good attempt to address the assessment criteria in the marking scheme, completing all items and most well. Good evidence of reading required material.	Well structured, well crafted and well delivered. Clear and coherent
50-59	Fair (Pass)	A fair submission. Demonstrates fair knowledge. Fair attempt to address the assessment criteria in the marking scheme, completing all items (some of them well), but making some errors and/or omissions, e.g. in planning, conducting or reporting of activities. Some evidence of reading.	Fairly well structured, fairly well crafted and fairly well delivered. Mostly clear and coherent

40-49	Satisfactory (Pass)	A competent submission. Demonstrates adequate knowledge. Adequate attempt to address the assessment criteria in the marking scheme, completing most items, but making several errors and/or omissions, e.g. in planning, conducting or reporting of activities. Evidence of some reading but demonstrates several gaps in knowledge.	Adequately structured, adequately crafted and adequately delivered. Somewhat clear and coherent
<40	Poor (Fail)	Demonstrates unsatisfactory knowledge. Does not succeed in grasping key issues and does not address most assessment criteria in marking scheme. Some items may be absent, incomplete or include major errors. Shows little or no evidence of reading required materials that were assigned.	Poorly structured, poorly crafted, and poorly delivered. Lacks clarity and/or coherence.

Grade bands INM355

%	Grade description	Knowledge demonstrated in the submission	Presentation & communication
80-100	Outstanding (High Distinction)	An outstanding submission. Demonstrates comprehensive knowledge. Addresses all assessment criteria in the marking scheme in full and is of a professional standard. Exceptionally strong evidence of creativity, independent and critical thinking, and reading of related work that is outside of the required reading.	Exceptionally well structured, exceptionally well crafted, and exceptionally well delivered. Exceptionally clear and coherent.
70-79	Excellent (Distinction)	An excellent submission. Demonstrates very strong knowledge. Very strong critical analysis evident. Addresses all assessment criteria in the marking scheme very well. Evidence of comprehensive reading of required material, and some reading of related work beyond this.	Very well structured, very well crafted and very well delivered. Very clear and coherent
60-69	Good (Merit)	A good submission. Demonstrates good knowledge. Good attempt to address the assessment criteria in the marking scheme, completing all items and most well. Good evidence of reading required material.	Well structured, well crafted and well delivered. Clear and coherent
50-59	Satisfactory (Pass)	A competent submission. Demonstrates adequate knowledge. Adequate attempt to address the assessment criteria in the marking scheme, completing all items (some of them well), but making some errors and/or omissions, e.g. in planning, conducting or reporting of activities. Evidence of some reading but demonstrates gaps in knowledge.	Adequately structured, adequately crafted and adequately delivered. Mostly clear and coherent
<50	Poor (Fail)	Demonstrates unsatisfactory knowledge. Does not succeed in grasping key issues and does not address most assessment criteria in marking scheme. Some items may be absent, incomplete or include major errors. Shows little or no evidence of reading required materials that were assigned.	Poorly structured, poorly crafted, and poorly delivered. Lacks clarity and/or coherence.